

SINGLE-SHOT BREECH-LOADING RIFLES

For many years, military authorities throughout the Western world had appreciated the benefits of breech-loading firearms. Muzzle-loading muskets and rifles were difficult to reload while a soldier was lying prone, and were also usually slower to load than a well-designed breech-loader. Breech-loading mechanisms continued to evolve. Many rifles began to be loaded at the breech using bolt action (see p.304), which would influence the future development of these arms. In the 19th century, a number of breech-loading weapons were taken into military service in Europe and North America. Many were efficient conversions of existing muzzle-loading rifles and would have a long service life.

▼ BALLARD RIFLE

Date 1862–66

Origin US

Barrel 28½in (72.4cm)

Caliber .54in

The Ballard rifle used a breech-loading mechanism called lever action, in which an under-lever was used to open the breech chamber. The rifle's scroll under-lever operated a pivoting breechblock.

